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“Anonymity isn’t that important online”

Many people assume anonymity is not necessary because “good” users shouldn’t have anything to hide. I see this belief a lot in online debates about social media and how policies require real names, emails, phone numbers, and other basic information. The argument usually goes that removing anonymity will make people more responsible and reduce harmful behavior. On the other hand, anonymity often enables people to speak honestly about sensitive issues. As Bruce Schneier explains in *Secrets and Lies*, workers at suicide or crisis hotlines understand the power of anonymity, as callers are more often willing to share deeply personal experiences because they do not have to share personal information. Support communities for abuse or addiction often also allow for anonymous participation. Without anonymity, many people would not seek help or share their stories. This also applies online, as Schneier explained in the book, anonymous online communication was crucial during the Balkan conflicts of the late 1990s to ensure truthful information made it out of dangerous regions without people revealing their identities. Fast forward to today, anonymous tools such as anonymous email accounts, pseudonyms, or privacy networks allow whistleblowers, journalists, and activists to safely communicate.

Believing that anonymity is unimportant can lead to systems that eliminate or weaken it. Governments and corporations may require strict identity validation for all online activity, arguing that this improves accountability. While this can be valuable, removing anonymity entirely creates serious risks. People may avoid talking about sensitive health issues, political views, or personal struggles if their identities are permanently attached to their statements. In cybersecurity, the loss of anonymity can also make individuals more vulnerable to surveillance, harassment, and targeting. Journalists reporting on powerful organizations may be exposed if they cannot communicate anonymously with sources. Whistleblowers might not decide to report wrongdoing if their statements can be traced back to them. Eliminating anonymity does not stop malicious behavior either. Attackers can still hide their identities using stolen accounts or infrastructure in other countries, while ordinary users who have a legitimate reason for privacy get the short end of the stick.

The reality is that anonymity is neither purely good nor purely bad. It is a tool that can be used for both beneficial and harmful purposes. Schneier goes on to explain that anonymity helps individuals speak freely about sensitive issues and share information without fear of retaliation, but it can also be used to enable harassment and other harmful actions. Because of the neutral nature of anonymity, the goal should not be to eliminate anonymity entirely, but to balance privacy with accountability. One approach we could use is to build platforms that protect user privacy while allowing investigation of series abuse under strict legal procedures. This preserves anonymity for legitimate use while still providing ways to address harmful activity. Anonymity is important because it allows free expression and protects vulnerable individuals. Rather than dismissing anonymity as unnecessary, cybersecurity experts should treat it as an important component of secure and ethical digital systems.